
Strategic Assumptions That Were Not Challenged

1941 World War II

Japan would avoid all-out war because it recognized US military superiority.

Given that US superiority would only increase, Japan might view a first strike as the only way to knock America out of the war.

1950s Korean War

China would not cross the Yalu River in support of the North Korean government.

Red China could make good on its threats to counter "US aggression" against the North.

1962 Cuban Missile Crisis

The Soviet Union would not introduce offensive nuclear weapons into Cuba.

The Kremlin could miscalculate and believe it could create a fait accompli that a young US President would not be prepared to reverse.

1973 Yom Kippur War

Arabs knew they could not win because they had failed to cooperate in the past and still lacked sufficient air defenses to counter Israeli airpower.

A surprise Arab attack, even if repelled, could wound Israel psychologically and prompt international calls for cease-fires and diplomatic negotiations.

1989 German Unification

East Germany could not unify with the West Germany against the wishes of the Soviet Union.

The Soviet Union—under Gorbachev—might not be prepared to intervene militarily in Eastern Europe as it had in the past.

1998 Indian Nuclear Test

Conducting a nuclear test risked international condemnation and US sanctions and would threaten a newly elected coalition government.

A successful and surprise nuclear test could boost Indian nationalist pride and solidify public support for a shaky coalition government.

2003 Iraq's WMD Programs

Saddam failed to cooperate with UN inspectors because he was continuing to develop weapons of mass destruction.

If Iraqi authorities had destroyed their WMD stocks and abandoned their programs, they might refuse to fully acknowledge this to the UN to maintain Iraq's regional status, deterrence, and internal regime stability.